

Observation

- Direct observation in the field
 - Structuring frameworks
 - Degree of participation (insider or outsider)
 - Ethnography
- Direct observation in controlled environments
- Indirect observation: tracking users' activities
 - Diaries
 - Interaction logging
 - Video and photographs collected remotely by drones or other equipment

Observation

Scenarios

1. A usability consultant joins a group of tourists and studies how they use a wearable navigation device to walk around Stockholm and find restaurants that they are interested in. Usability consultant observes that the interface is a little difficult to use, but users find it useful and enjoyable to find restaurants nearby.
2. A usability consultant observes how participants perform a pre-planned task using the wearable navigation device in a usability laboratory. The task requires users to find a specific restaurant, he records the time it takes to complete the task, and records and interactions.

What are the advantages and disadvantages of these two types of observations?

When might each type of observation be useful?

Scenario 1:

- Observer saw how the device is used to solve real problems in the real world.
- The Observer was an insider, and may not be objective in her assessment.
- The data is qualitative and how useful are they?
- Maybe she was having such a good time that her judgment was clouded and she missed hearing negative comments. If you wanted to reconduct the study, it would be impossible to replicate.

Scenario 2:

- This type of study is easy to replicate, so users can perform the same task, specific usability problems can be identified, users' performance can be compared, and averages for time to do the task, number of errors can be calculated.
- The observer can be more objective, because she is an outsider.
- Disadvantage: study is artificial and doesn't say anything about how the device would be used in the real environment.